inspection, now decked in cloth of gold and saddled with an elephant's howdah.[70]

Like Ranjit Singh, Burnes clearly had immense charm. It was this which, time after time, managed to disarm the most hostile situations.

The normally suspicious Ranjit wrote to the Governor General on the day of Burnes's departure to say how much he had enjoyed meeting this 'nightingale of the garden of eloquence, this bird of the winged words of sweet discourse'. After the Governor General had authorised Burnes to continue his journey into Afghanistan, the Afghans were no less delighted by him: the first chieftain he came across as he set foot on the Afghan bank of the Indus told him that he and his friends could 'feel as secure as eggs under a hen'. Burnes duly repaid the affection. 'I thought Peshawar a delightful place,' he wrote to his mother in Montrose a month later, 'until I came to Kabul: truly this is paradise . . . I tell them about steam ships, armies, ships, medicine, and all the wonders of Europe; and, in return, they enlighten me regarding the customs of their country, its history, state factions, trade &c . . .'[71] He felt a genuine fondness for the people, who 'are kind-hearted and hospitable; they have no prejudices against a Christian, and none against our nation. When they ask me if I like pork, I of course shudder and say it is only outcastes that commit such outrages. God forgive me! For I am very fond of bacon, and my mouth waters as I write the word.'

Burnes liked Kabul, liked its people, enjoyed its poetry and landscapes, and he admired its rulers. He went on to describe his warm reception by his Barakzai host, Dost Mohammad Khan, 'the most rising man in the Kabul dominions', and faithfully recounted the sparkling intelligence of his conversation, as well as the beauties of the gardens and fruit trees of his palace, the Bala Hisar.[72] If Burnes had charmed Dost Mohammad and his Afghans, they, in turn, had charmed him.

One man who remained stolidly immune to Burnes's attractions was Shah Shuja's keeper, the Ludhiana spymaster Claude Wade. Wade was never happy with anyone who stepped on his territory, which he tended to guard as jealously as any Afghan mastiff protecting its patch. He was certainly not going to put up with some social-climbing twenty-something overtaking him as the Governor General's preferred adviser on Afghanistan. While Ellenborough's Memorandum potentially gave Wade increased power,